

THE PERFORMERS



BANDEEP SINGH

KAPIL SIBAL

• HRD Minister

AGENDA Kapil Sibal's cup overflows: Laws to prevent, prohibit and punish educational malpractices, mandatory assessment and accreditation in higher education, regulating entry of Foreign Educational Providers, strengthening the Minority Education Commission and ensuring easy loans for students.

PERFORMANCE Any successor to Arjun Singh must come like a whiff of fresh air at Shastri Bhavan. Courted some controversy by scrapping the Class X exam from next year onwards and is now addressing key ground level concerns—shortage of teachers and educational institutions. Deserves kudos for removing bureaucrats from the top rung in institutions.



ANAND SHARMA

• Commerce Minister

AGENDA Policy initiatives to boost exports, special package for labour intensive sectors which had borne the brunt of the recession were the top priorities. Least and but no less important was signing of the long-pending free trade agreements with Korea and Asean.

PERFORMANCE 100 days is too short a time to reverse the negative trends in exports though there is a feeling of triumph at having finally signed two FTAs with Asean and Korea and scheduling a meeting of the G-20 countries in Delhi to "re-energise" the process of creating a fair trading regime.

THE AVERAGERS

JAIRAM RAMESH

• Environment Minister*

AGENDA Ramesh took over a ministry that had become dysfunctional, obstructionist, corrupt, poorly funded and out of sync with key issues, especially climate change. India's rivers are highly polluted, its tiger population is being poached to extinction and its afforestation programmes are stagnant.

PERFORMANCE He hit the ground running and has proved to be highly energetic, articulate and focused. He got his ministry's budget raised from Rs 3,600 crore to Rs 8,300 crore this year and persuaded the Supreme Court to free up Rs 11,000 crore for compensatory afforestation funds. He is putting the ministry firmly back on the climate change agenda, bringing greater accountability to wildlife preservation and is streamlining procedures for environmental clearances.



* Minister of State (Independent Charge) of the Ministry of Environment and Forests

SHOME BASU

